rather than water.[77] With such heated arguments, even colonial officials had to backtrack and reconsider their designs, bending straight lines into curves.

From such rudimentary beginnings, the state's power to acquire land and immovable property was extended considerably in 1850 to cover the railways, made uniform across regions in 1857, referred disputes to courts in 1870 and eventually culminated in the Land Acquisition Act of 1894.[78] Despite a few amendments, the basic spirit of this legislation survived till 2013 when India finally passed the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act. The difference in nomenclature reflected what had gone terribly wrong in the century between the two Acts, with land acquisition mired in serious issues of poor compensation, lack of transparency, lack of rehabilitation and, at times, even lack of resettlement.

Since 1894 and especially post-1947, large-scale development programmes acquired land on the principle of 'eminent domain' for the public good. Dams and irrigation projects accounted for the largest component of development-induced displacement with the submergence of vast tracts of land and thousands of villages. Resettlement and rehabilitation were after-thoughts. It was only after protracted social movements in the late 20th century that the government and donor agencies began to pay some attention to the severity of the issue. In one extreme example near the Alamatti dam in Karnataka in 1996–97, the dam construction schedule was not synchronized with people's relocation, catching them unawares of rising waters.[79] An emergency evacuation operation involving boats and helicopters had to be arranged as people were literally flooded out of their homes.

If resettlement was an issue in most projects, marked by delays and incomplete and poor housing sites, rehabilitation was not on the policy agenda for a long period of time. It was assumed that cash, land and houses were enough to tide over the problem. In reality, resettlement and involuntary displacement led to impoverishment risks of 'landlessness, joblessness, homelessness, marginalization, food insecurity, increased morbidity and mortality, loss of common property assets and social